American comic characters? I read the story and was bemused that a writer—with an English name like my own—could possibly be interested in an Indian chap on a Hero bike (not a Schwinn) in a mofussil town just like mine," he recalls.

Today, inspiration visits chiefly by night, and he laughs that his dream is a tablet he can write on with his fingertip so that the ideas are legible the next morning. When asked what brings joy, he lists: "Trees, birdcalls, baking bread (yesterday, dark chocolate beetroot cake), afternoons hammocked under the Persian lilac staring up at its lacework; the clouds above our roof terrace, any flock of egrets, street dogs, an open road, the moon at every phase, the night sky—though that crosses into awe."

Are new words being born out of this idyllic life? "Happenchance rules when it comes to the next book, and you try to make it as different as you can from the one that went before. Fact appears to rule in recent books: my last novel was a historical one on Asoka the king, but he became my Asoca, very much a fiction. I will say fiction comes harder of late, but invention was always hard for me." Sealy is working on a family history and a gazetteer of the Doon valley, where he lives. "But even there, I find irony creeping in and the selection turning whimsical. So, not a traditional gazetteer of the civil servant kind. I'm a rather uncivil servant," he says, with a twinkle in his eye. ■

***—Priya Pathiyan***

LITFEST ▼

# JUNGLE BOOKS

**THE FIRST-EVER CORBETT LITERATURE FESTIVAL WILL BRING WRITERS AND ARTISTS INTO DIALOGUE WITH SCIENTISTS, CONSERVATIONISTS AND FRONTLINE FOREST WORKERS**

Some stories are written on paper. Others are written by forests, rivers, mountains and the communities that live among them. The Corbett Literature Festival seeks to explore the latter.

According to Prerna Singh Bindra, advisor to the festival, the idea emerged from a recognition that the ecological crisis is also a crisis of culture and imagination. "Where a conventional literary festival begins with books and authors, this one begins with the landscape itself," she says. The festival brings writers and artists into dialogue with scientists, conservationists, historians, administrators and frontline forest workers.

Corbett offers a particularly resonant setting. The region is closely associated with Edward James Corbett, whose writings brought its forests and wildlife to a global readership. It was also among India's first tiger reserves and became the site of the launch of Project Tiger in 1973.

For Bindra, the urgent conversation today is about moving beyond the familiar narrative of human-wildlife conflict towards coexistence. "Conservation can no longer be a fringe issue; it must be mainstreamed into public discourse, media and national policy," she says, pointing to the pressures facing forests, rivers, wetlands and wildlife habitats across the Terai and Himalayas.

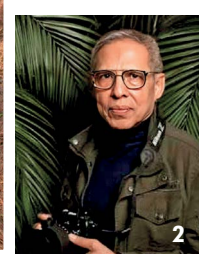
The three-day programme will span wildlife, ecology, nature writing, Himalayan culture, photography, filmmaking, food, music and storytelling. More than 20 sessions will feature over 30 voices from across these fields, including Namita Gokhale, Stephen Alter, Akash Das and Janhavi Prasada.

The experience is intended to extend beyond the festival's discussions. Guided field walks will introduce participants to local flora and avifauna, while photography and filmmaking masterclasses will offer new ways of seeing the wild. Local food, music and storytelling will connect ecological heritage with living culture. "The landscape itself becomes a 'participant' in the programme," says Bindra. "Direct sensory experience builds a far deeper connection." ■

***—Nikhil Sardana***

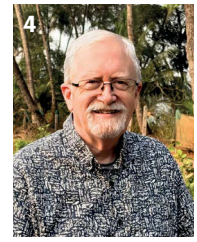
*The 3-night residential festival will take place from Oct. 6-9. For more details, visit www.corbettliteraturefest.org*










**1. PRERNA BINDRA** *Writer, conservationist*

**2. AKASH DAS** *Photographer, writer*

**3. NAMITA GOKHALE** *Writer, literary activist*

**4. STEPHEN ALTER** *Author and naturalist*